

Psalms 72

The King Whose Name Endures

His name shall endure for ever... men shall be blessed in him

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 Give the king thy judgments, O God, and thy righteousness unto the king's son.
- 2 He shall judge thy people with righteousness, and thy poor with judgment.
- 3 The mountains shall bring peace to the people, and the little hills, by righteousness.
- 4 He shall judge the poor of the people, he shall save the children of the needy, and shall break in pieces the oppressor.
- 5 They shall fear thee as long as the sun and moon endure, throughout all generations.
- 6 He shall come down like rain upon the mown grass: as showers that water the earth.
- 7 In his days shall the righteous flourish; and abundance of peace so long as the moon endureth.
- 8 He shall have dominion also from sea to sea, and from the river unto the ends of the earth.
- 9 They that dwell in the wilderness shall bow before him; and his enemies shall lick the dust.
- 10 The kings of Tarshish and of the isles shall bring presents: the kings of Sheba and Seba shall offer gifts.
- 11 Yea, all kings shall fall down before him: all nations shall serve him.
- 12 For he shall deliver the needy when he crieth; the poor also, and him that hath no helper.
- 13 He shall spare the poor and needy, and shall save the souls of the needy.
- 14 He shall redeem their soul from deceit and violence: and precious shall their blood be in his sight.
- 15 And he shall live, and to him shall be given of the gold of Sheba: prayer also shall be made for him continually; and daily shall he be praised.
- 16 There shall be an handful of corn in the earth upon the top of the mountains; the fruit thereof shall shake like Lebanon: and they of the city shall flourish like grass of the earth.
- 17 His name shall endure for ever: his name shall be continued as long as the sun: and men shall be blessed in him: all nations shall call him blessed.
- 18 Blessed be the LORD God, the God of Israel, who only doeth wondrous things.
- 19 And blessed be his glorious name for ever: and let the whole earth be filled with his glory; Amen, and Amen.
- 20 The prayers of David the son of Jesse are ended.

2 · CONTEXT

Superscribed for Solomon, Psalm 72 reads on the surface level as David's prayer for his son's coronation—justice for the poor, prosperity for the land, dominion to the ends of the earth. But the language quickly outgrows any merely human king: universal reign, endless duration, blessing extended to all nations. Henry and the broader Messianic tradition read it as reaching toward a greater Son of David; MacArthur-style notes treat Solomon's best moments as a shadow of Christ's perfect and everlasting kingship.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-4

The prayer opens with a request for righteous judgment given to the king, so that he may judge the people with justice and the poor with equity. The measure of good kingship here is not military glory but how the vulnerable are treated—mountains bringing peace, the poor being defended, the oppressor broken.

Verse 5-11

The king's reign is pictured in cosmic and universal terms: enduring as long as sun and moon, coming down like rain on the earth, dominion from sea to sea and to the ends of the world. Even rival kings and desert tribes are said to bow before him and bring tribute—language too large for any single historical monarch, straining toward the Messiah.

Verse 12-17

The center of the psalm turns to compassion: he delivers the needy when they cry, has pity on the poor, redeems their life from oppression and violence because their blood is precious to him. Prosperity for the land follows just rule; his name is prayed to endure forever, with all nations calling him blessed.

Verse 18-20

A closing doxology to the Lord God of Israel—who alone does wondrous things—caps the psalm, and the note 'the prayers of David are ended' marks a formal close to this earlier collection. The king's glory is finally swallowed up in the glory of God, whose praise fills the whole earth.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

True kingship, as this psalm defines it, is measured by justice for the poor and protection for the oppressed, not by conquest for its own sake. The language deliberately overflows any single ruler's lifetime, pointing forward to a King whose name and reign never end—one in whom, ultimately, all nations are blessed.

Application for life today.

Use this psalm to evaluate leadership—your own influence, or those you pray for—by its fruit for the vulnerable, not merely its scale or success. Let the psalm's global horizon expand your prayers beyond your own concerns toward the nations. And read the extravagant language as an invitation to hope in Christ's reign now, even while earthly kingdoms remain partial and passing.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. How does measuring good leadership by care for 'the poor and needy' (vv. 12–13) challenge how you evaluate leaders, including yourself?

2. Where do you see hints in this psalm that point beyond Solomon to Christ's everlasting kingdom?

3. What would it mean to pray for the nations with the same scope this psalm assumes (vv. 8–11, 17)?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).